Charcuterie Lab

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The Cheese Chart

100 cheeses in 8 families: how each one tastes, how strong it is, and what to serve with it.

THE 8 FAMILIES AT A GLANCE

Two things decide how a cheese tastes: how much water is left and how long it aged. Less water and more time means firmer and stronger. Three families get an extra step: blue mold, a washed rind, or something added.

FAMILY	TASTES	AGED	STRENGTH	FAMOUS EXAMPLES
1 **Fresh cheese**	Milky, tangy, mild	None to a few weeks (feta: 2+ months in brine)	Mild to medium	Mozzarella · Ricotta · Feta · Burrata
2 **Soft-ripened (bloomy rind)**	Buttery, mushroomy	3 to 8 weeks	Gentle to medium	Brie · Camembert · Humboldt Fog
3 **Semi-soft**	Mild, buttery	A few weeks to about 4 months	Mild to medium	Havarti · Monterey Jack · Young Gouda · Fontina
4 **Firm & semi-hard**	Nutty, savory, sharper with age	3 months to 2+ years	Mild to bold	Cheddar · Gruyère · Manchego · Comté
5 **Hard & aged**	Salty, savory, intense	About 6 months to 3+ years	Medium to bold	Parmigiano-Reggiano · Pecorino Romano · Aged Gouda
6 **Blue cheese**	Sharp, salty, peppery	2 to 6 months	Gentle to intense	Gorgonzola · Stilton · Roquefort
7 **Washed-rind**	Rich and meaty; smells strong	1 to 3 months	Medium to intense	Taleggio · Époisses · Limburger
8 **Flavored, smoked & specialty**	Whatever's added	Varies	Mild to medium	Smoked Gouda · Truffle cheese · Cranberry Wensleydale
+ **Plant-based (dairy-free)**	Nutty, tangy	Days to weeks	Mild to gentle	Cashew cheese · Vegan Brie

Strength: Mild · Gentle · Medium · Bold · Intense

IF YOU LIKE THIS, TRY THAT (EASY TO BOLD)

Soft and creamy	Brie	Camembert	Taleggio	Époisses
Nutty and firm	Swiss	Gruyère	Comté	Beaufort
Sharp	Mild cheddar	Aged cheddar	Aged Gouda	Parmigiano-Reggiano
Blue	Cambozola	Gorgonzola	Stilton	Roquefort
Goat	Midnight Moon	Fresh chèvre	Humboldt Fog	Crottin de Chavignol
Sheep	Pecorino Toscano	Manchego	Idiazábal	Pecorino Romano

GOOD TO KNOW

Building a board?
Pick one cheese from three families: a soft one (Brie), a firm one (Manchego) and a blue (Gorgonzola). Plan 2 oz of cheese per guest before a meal, 3 oz when the board is the party food.

Serving
Take hard cheese out of the fridge 45 to 60 minutes before serving and soft cheese 20 to 30 minutes before. Cold cheese tastes muted.

Milk changes the taste
Cow: mild and buttery. Goat: bright, tangy and white. Sheep: rich and nutty. Buffalo: very rich, mostly for mozzarella.

Pregnant?
In the US, most cheese made with pasteurized milk is fine. Be careful with soft Latin-style cheeses like queso fresco, and check the label.

All 100 cheeses (1 of 2)

Families 1–3: fresh, soft-ripened and semi-soft. Tick the ones you've tried.

CHEESE	MILK · FROM	STRENGTH	TASTES LIKE	TRY WITH	TRIED
1 Fresh cheese 15 cheeses					
Ricotta	Cow · Italy	●○○○○	Milky, faintly sweet, soft curds	Honey and lemon zest	☐
Cream Cheese	Cow · USA	●○○○○	Tangy, rich, smooth	Pepper jelly	☐
Mascarpone	Cow · Italy	●○○○○	Sweet, buttery, very rich	Fresh berries	☐
Fresh Mozzarella	Cow or buffalo · Italy	●○○○○	Milky, soft, delicate	Tomatoes and basil	☐
Burrata	Cow · Italy	●○○○○	Sweet milk with a creamy center	Prosciutto and peaches	☐
Stracciatella	Cow · Italy	●○○○○	Rich cream and soft shreds	Toast and olive oil	☐
Fresh Chèvre (Goat Cheese)	Goat · France	●●○○○	Bright, lemony, tangy	Honey	☐
Feta	Sheep · Greece	●●●○○	Salty, tangy, briny	Olives and cucumber	☐
Queso Fresco	Cow · Mexico	●○○○○	Milky, lightly salty, crumbly	Mango and chili	☐
Halloumi	Sheep, goat and cow · Cyprus	●●○○○	Salty, squeaky, firm	Watermelon or lemon	☐
Cheese Curds	Cow · USA	●○○○○	Squeaky, milky, salty	Cold beer	☐
Boursin	Cow · France	●●○○○	Garlic, herbs, creamy	Cucumber rounds	☐
Cottage Cheese	Cow · USA	●○○○○	Mild, milky, lumpy curds	Pineapple or peaches	☐
Paneer	Cow or buffalo · India	●○○○○	Mild, firm, doesn't melt	Mint chutney	☐
Queso Blanco	Cow · Latin America	●○○○○	Mild, milky, softens but won't melt	Salsa	☐
2 Soft-ripened (bloomy rind) 9 cheeses					
Brie	Cow · France	●●○○○	Buttery, mild, mushroomy	Fig jam	☐
Camembert	Cow · France	●●●○○	Earthy, mushroomy, savory	Apple slices	☐
Triple-Crème	Cow · France	●●○○○	Like rich butter, faintly tangy	Champagne	☐
Harbison	Cow · USA (Vermont)	●●●○○	Spoonable, woodsy, sweet cream	Crusty bread	☐
Humboldt Fog	Goat · USA (California)	●●●○○	Lemony, with a line of ash	Honey	☐
Bucheron	Goat · France	●●●○○	Tangy core, creamy edge	Pears	☐
Valençay	Goat · France	●●●○○	Lemony, nutty	Dried apricots	☐
Sainte-Maure de Touraine	Goat · France	●●●○○	Lemony, tangy, nutty	Walnuts	☐
Crottin de Chavignol	Goat · France	●●●○○	Nutty and tangy, firmer with age	Sancerre (white wine)	☐
3 Semi-soft 22 cheeses					
Havarti	Cow · Denmark	●○○○○	Buttery, mild, creamy	Apple slices	☐
Monterey Jack	Cow · USA	●○○○○	Mild, buttery	Salsa	☐
Colby Jack	Cow · USA	●○○○○	Mild, milky, marbled	Summer sausage	☐
Pepper Jack	Cow · USA	●●○○○	Mild with a chili kick	Salami	☐
Muenster	Cow · USA	●○○○○	Mild, buttery, orange rind	Rye bread	☐
Port Salut	Cow · France	●●○○○	Mild, creamy, savory	Pears	☐
Fontina	Cow · Italy	●●○○○	Nutty, earthy, buttery	Prosciutto	☐
Gouda (Young)	Cow · Netherlands	●○○○○	Sweet, buttery, mild	Apples	☐
Edam	Cow · Netherlands	●○○○○	Mild, slightly salty, red wax	Grapes	☐
Baby Swiss	Cow · USA	●○○○○	Mild, sweet, small holes	Ham	☐
Jarlsberg	Cow · Norway	●○○○○	Sweet, nutty, big holes	Pears	☐
Provolone	Cow · Italy / USA	●●○○○	Mild, milky, salty	Salami	☐
Morbier	Cow · France	●●○○○	Creamy, nutty, ash line through the middle	Walnuts	☐
Tomme de Savoie	Cow · France	●●○○○	Earthy, grassy, rustic	Apples	☐
Raclette	Cow · Switzerland / France	●●●○○	Savory, a bit funky, melts beautifully	Potatoes and cornichons	☐
Juustoleipä (Bread Cheese)	Cow · Finland	●○○○○	Buttery, toasted edges	Berry jam	☐
Colby	Cow · USA (Wisconsin)	●○○○○	Mild, soft, open texture	Apple slices	☐
Brick Cheese	Cow · USA (Wisconsin)	●●○○○	Mild young, tangy older	Detroit-style pizza	☐
Mozzarella (Low-Moisture)	Cow · USA / Italy	●○○○○	Mild, salty, stretchy	Pizza	☐
String Cheese	Cow · USA	●○○○○	Mild, peels into strings	Kids' snack boards	☐
Oaxaca	Cow · Mexico	●○○○○	Mild, buttery, stringy	Quesadillas	☐
American Cheese	Cow · USA	●○○○○	Salty, creamy, melts perfectly	Burgers	☐

All 100 cheeses (2 of 2)

Families 4–8 and plant-based: firm, hard, blue, washed-rind, flavored and dairy-free.

CHEESE	MILK · FROM	STRENGTH	TASTES LIKE	TRY WITH	TRIED
4 Firm & semi-hard 21 cheeses					
Cheddar (Mild)	Cow · England / USA	●●○○○	Mild, creamy, smooth	Crackers	☐
Cheddar (Aged)	Cow · England / USA	●●●●○	Sharp, tangy, crunchy crystals	Apples	☐
Gruyère	Cow · Switzerland	●●●○○	Nutty, brothy, savory	Pears	☐
Comté	Cow · France	●●●○○	Nutty, brown butter	Walnuts	☐
Beaufort	Cow · France	●●●○○	Fruity, floral, rich	Dried fruit	☐
Emmental	Cow · Switzerland	●○○○○	Mild, sweet, big holes	Ham	☐
Swiss (American-Style)	Cow · USA	●○○○○	Mild, nutty, big holes	Turkey or ham	☐
Manchego	Sheep · Spain	●●●○○	Nutty, buttery	Membrillo (quince paste)	☐
Mahón	Cow · Spain	●●●○○	Buttery, tangy, salty	Marcona almonds	☐
Idiazábal	Sheep · Spain	●●●○○	Nutty, buttery, often lightly smoked	Green olives	☐
Ossau-Iraty	Sheep · France	●●●○○	Buttery, nutty, sweet	Black cherry jam	☐
Pecorino Toscano	Sheep · Italy	●●○○○	Buttery, mild sheep tang	Honey and pears	☐
Roncal	Sheep · Spain	●●●○○	Nutty, salty, herbal	Quince paste	☐
Garrotxa	Goat · Spain	●●○○○	Nutty, herbal, mild goat	Figs	☐
Drunken Goat	Goat · Spain	●●○○○	Mild, sweet, wine-soaked rind	Red grapes	☐
Midnight Moon	Goat · Netherlands	●●○○○	Brown butter, caramel	Apple slices	☐
Red Leicester	Cow · England	●●○○○	Mellow, sweet, nutty	Chutney	☐
Asiago	Cow · Italy	●●○○○	Mild young, sharp aged	Salami	☐
Aged Provolone	Cow · Italy	●●●●○	Sharp, piquant, salty	Roasted red peppers	☐
Tête de Moine	Cow · Switzerland	●●●○○	Nutty, earthy, shaved into rosettes	Pears	☐
Ricotta Salata	Sheep · Italy	●●○○○	Salty, milky, firm crumbles	Tomatoes	☐
5 Hard & aged 7 cheeses					
Parmigiano-Reggiano	Cow · Italy	●●●●○	Savory, nutty, crunchy crystals	Aged balsamic	☐
Parmesan (Domestic)	Cow · USA	●●●○○	Savory, salty	Pasta	☐
Grana Padano	Cow · Italy	●●●○○	Nutty, mildly sweet	Honey	☐
Pecorino Romano	Sheep · Italy	●●●●○	Very salty, sharp	Pears and honey	☐
Aged Gouda	Cow · Netherlands	●●●●○	Butterscotch, crunchy crystals	Dark chocolate	☐
Mimolette	Cow · France	●●●○○	Nutty, butterscotch, bright orange	Beer	☐
Cotija	Cow · Mexico	●●●○○	Very salty, crumbly	Elote (street corn)	☐
6 Blue cheese 9 cheeses					
Cambozola	Cow · Germany	●●○○○	Buttery, gentle blue	Pears	☐
Gorgonzola	Cow · Italy	●●●○○	Creamy, tangy (dolce is milder)	Walnuts and honey	☐
Bleu d'Auvergne	Cow · France	●●●○○	Creamy, grassy, clean	Pears	☐
Danish Blue	Cow · Denmark	●●●○○	Salty, sharp, straightforward	Walnuts	☐
Maytag Blue	Cow · USA (Iowa)	●●●●○	Sharp, lemony, salty	Apples	☐
Stilton	Cow · England	●●●●○	Nutty, savory, mellow blue	Port	☐
Rogue River Blue	Cow · USA (Oregon)	●●●●○	Fruity, boozy, wrapped in leaves	Pears	☐
Roquefort	Sheep · France	●●●●●	Sharp, very salty, intense	Sauternes or honey	☐
Cabrales	Cow · Spain	●●●●●	Very sharp, spicy, salty	Figs	☐
7 Washed-rind 7 cheeses					
Taleggio	Cow · Italy	●●●○○	Buttery, fruity; milder than it smells	Honey	☐
Reblochon	Cow · France	●●●○○	Nutty, buttery, savory	Potatoes (tartiflette)	☐
Pont-l'Évêque	Cow · France	●●●○○	Rich, savory, faintly sweet	Hard cider	☐
Red Hawk	Cow · USA (California)	●●●●○	Beefy, rich, tangy	Beer	☐
Langres	Cow · France	●●●●○	Rich, tangy, funky	Champagne	☐
Limburger	Cow · Belgium / Germany	●●●●○	Strong smell, surprisingly mild taste	Rye bread and onion	☐
Époisses	Cow · France	●●●●●	Rich, meaty, spoonable	Crusty bread	☐
8 Flavored, smoked & specialty 6 cheeses					
Smoked Gouda	Cow · Netherlands / USA	●●○○○	Smoky, mild, buttery	Summer sausage	☐
Truffle Cheese	Cow or sheep · Italy	●●●○○	Earthy, garlicky, savory	Honey	☐
Cotswold	Cow · England	●●○○○	Oniony, chives, buttery	Ham	☐
Wensleydale with Cranberries	Cow · England	●○○○○	Mild, honeyed, sweet-tart fruit	Oatcakes	☐
Cranberry Goat Cheese	Goat · USA	●●○○○	Tangy with sweet-tart fruit	Pecans	☐
Brunost	Whey · Norway	●●○○○	Caramel, dulce de leche	Waffles	☐
+ Plant-based (dairy-free) 4 cheeses					
Cashew Cheese	Cashews	●●○○○	Rich, nutty, tangy when cultured	Crackers and herbs	☐
Almond Ricotta	Almonds	●○○○○	Mild, nutty, lemony	Roasted tomatoes	☐
Vegan Brie	Cashews or coconut	●●○○○	Rich, tangy, faintly mushroomy	Fig jam	☐
Vegan Cream Cheese	Nuts, soy or oats	●○○○○	Tangy, clean, spreadable	Bagels	☐